

to believe that he has done most of his schooling from Telugu-medium government schools.

"I was privileged to be taught by very sincere and committed teachers right from my school to college days. The foundation that we got in terms of math and physics was very good," explains Venkata. Fun fact, his father also taught at the same school, and Venkata continued to draw inspiration from him.

However, it was not just physics and math that Venkata was interested in. He was an active participant in all the sporting events taking place in his school and college. The small town experience, mixed with exposure to various sports and English learning, as Venkata explains, has helped make him what he is today.

"The schools in the town used to have really big playgrounds, and we used to go play every evening. I feel blessed to have had a well-rounded balanced childhood life. I really enjoyed the experience in that small town," he says.

One of the things that pulled him back towards home from those playgrounds, and something that he still relishes, are mutton and seafood curries prepared by his mother. One of the things that Venkata cherishes about his childhood is the absence of rat-race to always secure first rank in exams. He is thankful to his parents about not putting too much pressure on him for securing top ranks in any of the standards.

"My parents always told me about the importance of studies but never punished me for not standing on the top in any of the exams. They always wanted me to be an all-rounder when it came to studies, sports or life," he says proudly.

While his parents never put pressure around studies, Venkata, most of the time, secured first rank in most of the academic years of life. As interesting as it gets, Venkata was part of a group of around ten students who always finished in top ten and competed among themselves to secure the top ranks.

"I used to be in the top five, and there were instances when I was first. The competition among the friends was the best. We motivated and also



Venkata with wife Srilaxmi at Everest Base Camp Hike

competed against each other," he recalls.

Venkata moved to the city of Vizag in Andhra Pradesh to pursue higher studies. He got admission in an engineering course in Andhra University college of Engineering.

"We, me and my father, still have conversations around concepts of physics. He is 82 years young and continues to excite me with his knowledge of the latest research in physics," he says.

Life ping-pong way

In a nation filled with cricket enthusiasts all over, Venkata loved holding a ping-pong (table tennis) racket. So much so that he won most of the tournaments at school level in his academic days. He continues playing table-tennis in the USA at a club which has given three international players to the country. And ping-pong, as he refers to it, is not just a game, it is a way one can live his life!

"Ping-pong taught me that you do not always win in life. There are some sets where you lose, and somewhere you win, but the best part is felt when you learn to enjoy yourself. Ping-pong is one of those games where you are involved every second in the game, just the way you should be in what to pursue to do in life. It should be about winning, but it should be more about having fun," he explains.

He is not just a leader who finds

inspiration from a game, but also from players and others who make great games possible. For example, he admires a table tennis player named Rajul Sheth, who has not only played well on many levels but also created a table tennis club from scratch in USA that produced Olympic players. This club is the same place where Venkata still goes to play. This club has given international players to the country; these players have also represented the USA at the Olympics!

"The best of players know when to make way for others. They not only facilitate conditions for others to grow but they also make sure their fellow players do not make the same mistakes they have made in yesteryears. If something has given you, be it a sport or a person, it is your duty to give back to others," he shares his views.

"I admire executives like Satya Nadella and others because I think they have learnt the importance of being a team player from the sports they have played in life. Nadella used to be a good cricketer, and I am sure that sport has helped him in understanding how a team functions. Sports definitely teach you things that cannot be taught in a classroom," he explains.

"In sports there is only winning or losing, there is nothing in between," he adds. Talking about winning, losing and sports, where is this table tennis